People join Freemasonry for many different reasons, but among the benefits reported of membership are fun, enjoyment, making new friends and a sense of personal achievement and satisfaction.

This thread includes a series of positive activities a Lodge can undertake to help a member to grow in his satisfaction, enjoyment and – therefore – commitment, as well as preventive activities, to respond to any signs of dissatisfaction or disengagement.

It also considers the role of clubs and societies beyond the Lodge and how they can enhance a member's experience of Freemasonry and increase the sense of fun and enjoyment.

WHY DO WE NEED TO FOCUS ON MEMBER SATISFACTION?

- Completing the degree ceremonies are only the beginning of Freemasonry, and of a membership experience that we hope will last for many years.
- How a Lodge looks after and nurtures each member will determine whether their membership will be long and happy and the extent to which they will be involved in the Lodge and committed as a Freemason.
- A major cause of dissatisfaction and resignation arises from people issues such as personality clashes, decisions (or the way they are made), from being overlooked or not being treated as one feels one ought.
- Another is when a Lodge does not recognise or respond to a member's needs, or when they perceive it does not offer them anything of value. Lodges which, during the Covid-19 pandemic, did not engage with members and offer them value for their membership (for example via online social and educational gatherings, buddy systems, etc) have found an increase in member "detachment" and resignations.
- Every member's circumstances, interests and needs will change during their membership. If a member feels the Lodge is not engaging with them, understanding what they currently want or is neglecting their needs, they may resign.
- Any resignation is a sad loss to the Lodge. Most that arise from dissatisfaction are avoidable through careful management of the Lodge and its people issues.
- Understanding and looking after the interests of each member as an individual, with their own needs and characteristics, balanced against the needs of all members and the Lodge itself, will normally avoid such dissatisfaction and minimise resignations.
- A Lodge with dissatisfied, disengaged or neglected members will have more resignations than one with satisfied and engaged members, prompting a decline in overall membership and eventually in the health and viability of the Lodge.

WHAT A LODGE CAN DO

- Build a Lodge culture with a nurturing approach, or "continued mentoring" (see "Personal learning"), that considers the needs of all members and treats all members as they would wish to be treated themselves.
- Contact all members regularly, especially those who do not or cannot attend Lodge meetings.
- Increase contact during long breaks between Lodge meetings.
- Use varied methods, including a buddy system, birthday cards, phone calls, email Lodge newsletters, social media (eg, Lodge Facebook and WhatsApp groups) and online video calls (eg, Facetime, Skype, Zoom).
- Find ways to involve every member in the life of the Lodge, through formal or informal roles and contributions suited to them, to increase their sense of belonging, interest and commitment.
- By their conduct the senior members set the tone of the Lodge. Other members follow their example.
- Seniority brings with it a responsibility to lead by example, to set high standards of behaviour and to demonstrate the essential characteristics of a Freemason; integrity, friendship, respect and charity.
- All brethren are reminded of the Board of General Purposes' statement on standards and values and of the expectation to show respect for the dignity and privacy of individuals.
- Be alert to conduct that is contrary to Freemasonry's principles, inappropriate behaviour and discouraging or negative exchanges, all of which undermine the interest and confidence of members and the harmony and health of the Lodge.
- Seek the advice or assistance of the Lodge's Visiting or Liaison Officer or another respected Freemason if, as a Lodge, you are unable to manage any poor conduct of any senior members.
- Plan meetings to be enjoyable, interesting and informative, with a good atmosphere and good ritual, to meet the expectations of members and to assist their self-improvement.
- Encourage members to undertake regular learning about Freemasonry, using Solomon, UGLE's online learning platform, and other reliable sources.
- Ensure administrative business and activities are planned in advance and conducted in the minimum time required. Working members are accustomed to business meetings being well prepared, conducted efficiently, free of distractions or irrelevance. They expect the same of Lodge business.
- Encourage members to deliver ritual to the best of their ability, to create a good and meaningful experience for candidates, members and visitors.
- Except on occasions when protocol dictates (such as official visits by rulers) encourage those members not in office to sit in different places with different people in the Lodge Room and at the Festive Board.
- Review Lodge traditions to confirm whether they are still relevant and serve the Lodge well. Change or evolve any traditions that might harm the future health of the Lodge.
- Consider new approaches that enhance meetings without losing dignity or those Lodge traditions that are worth keeping.
- Aim for meetings that are attractive and worthwhile, that add value to members' lives and help to maintain their interest and commitment, and so improve attendance and retention.

- Monitor attendance to identify early signs of dissatisfaction or difficulty. Agree as a Lodge how to respond and who will take action (See "Tracking attendance and apologies").
- Maintain contact with those members who are not able to attend as often as they would like, to retain their interest, support and – ultimately – their membership.
- "Engage with non-attending Members" looks at the warning signs for a possible resignation, how that can be averted and what actions can be taken in the event that a member does resign.
- Monitor the number of members joining and the number leaving over a rolling five-year period, to see if the Lodge is growing or declining.

THE ROLE OF CLUBS AND ASSOCIATIONS IN FREEMASONRY

- Although we join Freemasonry through one Lodge, once a member there are many other groups, clubs and associations that can enhance a member's enjoyment and satisfaction.
- The membership criteria for Light Blues Clubs (LBCs), sometimes called New & Young Masons Clubs (N&YMCs), vary from club to club. They tend to be for Freemasons who have not achieved Provincial rank and / or those who are under a certain age.
- They are organised at Metropolitan / Provincial / District levels and are supported by UGLE.
- They tend to be self-managing, under a constitution approved by the Metropolitan / Provincial / District Grand Master and adopted by the members, with a senior member of the Province appointed to oversee and guide them.
- Although each club's specific objectives vary, they all tend to offer social and educational activities beyond the Lodge.
- Therefore, they enhance a member's experience of Freemasonry, widen their circle of friends, and help them build networks that will probably continue for many years.
- For brethren joining Lodges that have few others of their age and experience, a Light Blues Club can complement what they receive in their Lodge and make all the difference between overall satisfaction or dissatisfaction.
- Freemasons have formed other types of clubs and associations, to enhance member enjoyment and satisfaction. The following are just some examples of broad categories:
  - Lodge Associations, comprising Lodges that share a common interest such as links to the armed or emergency services, schools, professions, youth organisations, etc.
  - Member Associations, comprising individual Freemasons who share a common interest such as a particular sport, music, caravanning, etc.
  - Masters' Associations, comprising those who served as Master in a particular year or locality.
  - Research societies, comprising members who wish to research Freemasonry, its history and development.
  - Provincial clubs and societies, being member associations in a particular Province.
- In addition, many members get involved in social media such as Twitter and Facebook groups, connect with members and non-members and share their enthusiasm for Freemasonry.

FINALLY

Lodges can monitor satisfaction in a structured way, using satisfaction or engagement surveys and by monitoring attendance and early warning signs of possible resignations.

Ultimately, members who continue to enjoy Freemasonry, and derive satisfaction from it as their needs and interests change and develop, will remain in membership. Those who find Freemasonry does not provide them with value will leave.